

HOW TO PRACTICE SPEAKING ENGLISH ALONE FOR FREE

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About the Author

Keith runs The Keith Speaking Academy. He has been working in international education for over 20 years as a teacher, teacher trainer, and education manager.

He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.



In this article I will share **13 awesome ways** you can practice speaking English alone at home for free.

Not everyone has access to native speaker friends or colleagues, in person classes, a teacher or even English groups to practice their English.

Yet, practice is a key part to improving your **fluency** and overall speaking ability.

Practicing some common questions and answers is also a key part of **preparing for IELTS Speaking**



1. SPEAK INTO THE MIRROR

This is easy because you can do it when you wash your face in the morning and at night.

It's most likely a routine you already have.

For example, in the morning, when I was practicing Chinese, I would say what I was **going to do** that day,

'Today I am going to meet Jack. I am going to go to the gym. I am going to....'

At night, I would say what I had done that day, and how it went.

'Today was good. I went for a walk, I started reading a new book, I didn't burn dinner...'

2. PRACTICE WITH SHORT AUDIOS

There are lots of audios you can use, such as **IELTS sample answers**, or **podcasts** or **Youtube videos**.

Here is what you can do.

- **First**, listen to sample answers/audio and pause it, to repeat some key phrases, or phrases you like
- **Second**, practice re-telling the audio using similar language to what you heard.

This is not the same as memorising it all. You are just practicing using some of the key phrases.

- **Then**, try re-telling the episode, and recording yourself.
- **Finally**, listen back and check with the transcript (if there is one) to see if you got the phrases right (this is really good for learning and practicing **collocations**)

3. IMITATE YOUR FAVOURITE ENGLISH- SPEAKING ACTORS

When you watch a film in English, with your favourite actor, try and **repeat what they say**, and **try to sound like them**. You can even **move** like them.

You can always check the words they say, by checking the subtitles.

But, don't read the subtitles aloud!

You just use them to check what was said.

When speaking – **don't read the words**; this will not help your speaking (even though you think it is easier – it is not helping you).

Why does 'imitating actors' work?

Identity is a key part of language speaking.

When you 'pretend' to be someone else (in this case an English actor), it is sometimes easier to pick up the right pronunciation and intonation.

You stop being you, and become someone else.

Try it out – it can be great fun!

4. SEND AUDIO MESSAGES

Instead of texting your friends/speaking partner on what's app, try sending audio messages in English.

The great thing about audio messages is there is no pressure, unlike a phone call.

You have time to prepare, and if you don't like the message you can always delete it.

Another trick is to **set up your phone in English**.

This includes setting up Siri, Google or Alexa (depending on your phone) in **English**.

So when you ask Siri – you ask in English.

It also pushes you to get the pronunciation right, or Siri won't answer you!

5. IMITATE THE ENGLISH FOREIGNER

You know how English people (or American, or Canadian...) sound when they speak your native language, right?

Well, try imitating them and their accent.

- So **first**, speak your native language like an English person does.
- **Then**, keep that same crazy pronunciation and sound, and start speaking English.

It's almost like you are pretending to be English.

Like, you have a new **identity** as an English person.

6. PRACTICE SPEAKING ENGLISH ALONE BY SHADOWING

Yes, a **shadow** is the dark area any body leaves when it is between the sun and the ground.

However the verb, '**to shadow**', means to follow someone.

Shadowing in language learning, is when you **follow someone's voice**.

So, you listen to a short audio (maybe 30 seconds, not too easy, not too difficult).

As you listen a second time, you try to speak at the same time as the voice, following it, saying the same thing.

Sounds crazy, but once you practice this a few times, you will start to get the pronunciation and the fluency of the speaker.

IELTS sample answers, if they have the audio, are good for this.

You can also try some **elementary podcasts** like these.

7. PRACTICE RESPONDING

You can read my **complete article about responding**, but briefly, **responding** is

1. **Hearing a question,**
2. **Quickly getting ideas,**
3. **Putting the ideas into spoken words**

It is an essential skill to practice, but few students do it.

It's easy to set up.

- Go to **My Youtube channel**
- Find the **playlist called Responding CITIES**
- Play the recording in shuffle mode (so you don't know which question is coming)
- Answer in real time (30 seconds for part 1 Qu. and 50 seconds for part 2 Qu.)
- Repeat everyday

8. DESCRIBE WHAT YOU ARE DOING (ALOUD)

Some students try this with thinking.

Think about what you are doing in English at any moment.

Or for example, as you go for a walk, think in English.

Describe **what you see, how you feel**....always thinking in English.

Well, this is similar, but instead of thinking, **you are talking to yourself**.

Will I look silly?

No way, hey, people speak into phone microphones all the time!

Simple – but very powerful!

9. SING IN ENGLISH

Find a song you like in English.

Learn the lyrics (words).

Sing it aloud.

2 great websites / apps to get started with lyrics are

<https://www.lyrics.com> (free lyrics)

<https://lyricstraining.com/> (the coolest, free, game-based approach to learning a language)



10. TRY TONGUE TWISTERS

These are more about pronunciation practice, but they are fun.

You try repeating a sentence that repeats difficult or similar sounds.

It's a great gym workout for your mouth.

You can try [these simple Tongue Twisters with audio download](#)

Also watch [this video with 4 popular ones](#)

And then try making up your own.

Go for it!



11. PRACTICE IDIOMS WITH YOUNGLISH

This Internet is a fantastic source of tools and materials for practicing speaking English alone at home, and this is one of my favourites.

<https://youenglish.com>

It's like a **search engine** that plays a video clip with any word or phrase you enter.

Most clips are from films or T.V. series.

You can practice repeating any phrase you want, but the really good thing about it, is you can practice **correct intonation**.

In fact, for each phrase, there are lots of video clip examples, so you can see how the phrase is used in different contexts.

Brilliant for idioms!

12. IMMERSE YOURSELF IN ENGLISH

Do a **lifestyle audit**.

Where do you use your native language everyday?

Maybe when...

- using your phone,
- using your computer,
- listening to podcasts,
- self-talking,
- watching tv,
- listening to music....

Which of these can you use/do in English?

For example, can you change your phone/computer settings to English?

Can you listen to some English songs?

Can you choose some English podcasts?

Look for ways to bring English into your life and surround yourself with English, and you can practice more naturally everyday.

13. PRACTICE SPEAKING ALONE REGULARLY

Think about **Goals** and **Habits**.

1. Set yourself a short term goal to practice speaking.

- 5 days, 2 weeks, 30 days, whatever, just don't leave it open.
- Even if you carry on later, as humans, we like boundaries.
- Things we can measure.
- Boxes we can fit into.

2. Do this everyday

- Just start with 5 minutes, no more.
- When you are ready, increase the time.
- When you don't feel like it, and there will be days like this, just say, I will just do 1 minute – and that's enough.
- It will make a difference.

3. If possible, always do your speaking at the same time of day, and in the same place (this helps create a habit)

4. Language learning is up and down, It is not a linear process.

- Some days, you will feel like you are going backwards.
- This is normal.

If you enjoyed this article, you might also find [these tips on how to prepare for IELTS Speaking](#) useful too.

For more tips and ideas to improve your performance in IELTS Speaking, check out the [resources page](#) on this website.



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